

When Working With **EMERGING TECHNOLOGIES**, Sanity Is The Key!

Many believe that the Internet of Things, artificial intelligence or automation will solve their problems for good, only to find themselves in a differently flavoured soup post-implementation. Read on to find out why this happens



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Once upon a time (read as several years ago), while I was working with a home appliance manufacturing company in the early days of my career, an interesting incident happened. A group of us used to report to a senior manager, who was quite steadfast in pushing certain things, especially when he had made up his mind about something. One day he asked us to prepare a report, where certain things needed to be highlighted in italics and/or coloured fonts, and then print it and give it to him.

The only (big) problem was that we were using a program called WordStar, and all we had was a dot-matrix printer. For those who do not know, it was a disk operating system (DOS)-based word processor program. And, I believe I do not have to explain why having a dot-matrix printer was a problem for the given task.

Our obvious response was, “Not possible!” He would not listen and kept pushing us to make it happen. He insisted, saying something on the lines of, “Do not try to fool me; I know that the computer can do anything, and your boss promised

that to us when buying it!”

So, we stared at our boss, with rather mixed feelings, waiting for him to own it—after all, he promised the impossible—and fix it. Eventually, he did something behind the scenes and saved us.

But that incident left a strong impression on my green-self. This was not just the case of over-promising but also one where business expectations were inappropriate. Our interactions (with that senior manager) remained full of friction thereafter as we lost some credibility during the battle.

Then and now...

Fast forward to today, almost twenty years have passed and here we are, still dealing with such problems. It feels like a *déjà vu*, but why?

For some reason, people have increasingly started to assume that computers are better than humans and can do wonders. What is more, their assumption says that humans may get it wrong sometimes, but computers will not, ever! This assumption is posing a different set of challenges to humans.

